Northwind Labs Code of Conduct & IT Security

Revision 3.1 | Compliance & Information Assurance

1. Standards of Ethical Business Conduct

Northwind Labs operates on foundational pillars of honesty, legal compliance, and unwavering ethical standards. Employees must strictly avoid any activities or relationships that present a conflict between personal interests and company duties. Secondary employment, outside consulting, or commercial board seats require prior written disclosure and formal authorization from the Chief Legal Officer.

2. Gifts, Hospitality, and Entertainment Policy

Employees are strictly prohibited from accepting personal gifts, entertainment, or meals from vendors, clients, or competitors that exceed $50 in estimated fair market value. Any business gift or meal valued between $25 and $50 must be reported and logged in the Northwind Compliance Portal within 5 business days of receipt. Cash, gift cards, prepaid debit cards, or cryptocurrency gifts of any value are unconditionally prohibited under all circumstances.

3. Equal Treatment & Anti-Harassment Standards

Northwind Labs enforces zero tolerance for discrimination, harassment, or bullying based on race, sex, age, religion, disability, gender identity, or sexual orientation. Every employee is expected to treat coworkers, clients, and partners with dignity and professional respect.

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4. Whistleblower Protection & Non-Retaliation Policy

Northwind Labs fosters an open reporting culture. Employees who report suspected financial fraud, safety hazards, unlawful acts, or code of conduct violations in good faith are protected from any form of retaliation, demotion, termination, or harassment. Reports may be submitted 24/7 on a completely anonymous basis via the Northwind Ethics Hotline at 1-800-555-NWND (1-800-555-6963) or through our secure web portal at ethics.northwindlabs.com. Any manager found engaging in retaliation will face immediate termination.

5. Confidentiality & Intellectual Property

All proprietary research, source code, algorithm models, product blueprints, customer datasets, and strategic roadmaps developed at Northwind Labs represent exclusive company property. Proprietary information must never be copied, transferred to personal accounts, or uploaded to third-party public AI services. Non-disclosure obligations persist indefinitely following departure from the company.

6. Social Media & Public Communications

Only designated corporate communications spokespersons are authorized to speak to the media or post official announcements on behalf of Northwind Labs. Personal social media commentary regarding company business must include the explicit disclaimer: 'Opinions expressed are solely my own.'

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7. Password & Authentication Security Standards

All employee domain and application credentials must adhere to strict corporate security requirements: Passwords must contain a minimum length of 14 characters, combining uppercase letters, lowercase letters, numbers, and at least one special symbol. Passwords must be rotated every 90 days and cannot be reused within 10 password change cycles. Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) is strictly mandatory for all systems using Okta Verify push notifications or hardware FIDO2 keys (YubiKey). SMS/text-based 2FA is explicitly banned due to SIM-swap vulnerabilities.

8. Clean Desk & Physical Workplace Security

Employees must manually lock their computer workstations (Windows Key + L or Command + Control + Q) whenever leaving their desk. All corporate laptops are enforced with automatic screensaver locks requiring password reentry after 5 minutes of inactivity. Under our clean desk policy, all sensitive hardcopy documents, whiteboard notes, removable media, and security keycards must be locked in desk drawers or filing cabinets prior to departing the office at the end of each workday.

9. Wireless Network Security

While traveling or working remotely, connecting company laptops to public, unsecured Wi-Fi networks (e.g., airports, coffee shops, hotels) without an active Northwind GlobalProtect VPN session is strictly forbidden.

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10. Security Incident Reporting & Response

Rapid incident response is vital to preserving organizational cyber defense. Any employee who discovers or suspects a security breach, compromised password, phishing click, malware infection, unauthorized data access, or lost/stolen hardware device must report it immediately to the IT Security Operations Center (SOC). Reports must be sent to security@northwindlabs.com or reported via telephone to the Emergency Security Hotline (ext. 4357 / HELP) within a strict maximum window of 2 hours from discovery. Failure to report a known compromise within 2 hours is grounds for disciplinary action.

11. Device Management & Removable Media Policy

All company-issued laptops are managed via centralized endpoint detection and response (EDR) software. The use of external USB flash drives, unapproved external hard drives, and SD memory cards is disabled by default on all company workstations. If external storage is required for business purposes, an encrypted company-issued drive must be requested through IT Helpdesk.

12. Mobile Device & BYOD Rules

Employees accessing company email, Slack, or corporate networks on personal mobile devices must enroll their device in Microsoft Intune Mobile Device Management (MDM). Enrolled devices must enforce biometric or PIN lock and allow remote company data wipe upon loss or termination. Jailbroken or rooted smartphones are strictly barred from accessing company systems.